

ResumeForge

Founder's Day-One Plan — Launching from VIT Chennai (B.Tech CSE, AI & ML)

A phased 90-day roadmap — from a live product to traction, mentorship, and funding

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You are arriving on campus with something almost no first-year has: a **live, deployed product with real code** — not a pitch-deck idea. On a campus of thousands of CS students who all need internships and placements, you are also sitting *inside your exact target market*. Your job in the first 90 days is not to “run a startup.” It is to plug into the ecosystem, turn the people around you into your first users, find a co-founder and a mentor, and generate the evidence of demand that everything else (grants, incubation, funding) depends on. This document lays that out phase by phase.

1. Your Starting Advantage

Most student founders start from zero: an idea, a slide, and enthusiasm. You start from a working product (ResumeForge: an AI, proof-backed resume + interview-prep platform), a real codebase, and a clear wedge for a specific audience. That means you skip the riskiest 6–12 months and can walk into any incubator or faculty office and say “*I already ship — here is a live demo and my first users.*” That single sentence puts you ahead of 95% of applicants. The plan below is designed to compound that advantage instead of wasting it on premature company-building.

2. Guiding Principles

These five principles govern every decision in the plan:

1. **Academics are an asset, not an obstacle.** A strong first year buys you credibility, time, and the AI/ML foundation your product runs on. Never trade your CGPA or health for a sprint — you have years of runway.
2. **Users before structure.** No incorporation, no hiring, no fundraising until you have paying users and retention. Those are distractions at your stage.
3. **Take the free money first.** As an India-based student, non-dilutive government grants and

on-campus incubation are five minutes from your dorm. Use them before you ever pay a lawyer to set up a foreign entity.

4. **Lead with the wedge.** Market the *proof-backed resume + interview defense*, not “AI resume builder” (a crowded category) and not auto-apply (which carries platform/ToS risk).
5. **Your campus is your unfair advantage.** First users, your co-founder, mentors, and your first grant all live within walking distance. Mine it relentlessly.

3. The Plan at a Glance

Phase	Timeframe	Primary Goal	Success Marker
Phase 0	Day 1 – Week 1	Plug into the ecosystem	Joined E-Cell, found V-NEST, met 1 faculty mentor
Phase 1	Weeks 2 – 4	First users + feedback loop	20–30 active student users, 5 deep interviews
Phase 2	Days 30 – 90	Traction & proof	10 paying users, clear week-2 retention
Phase 3	Semester 1 – 2	Incubation, grants, structure	V-NEST application in, grant shortlist mapped

4. Phase 0 — Day 1 to Week 1: Plug Into the Ecosystem

Objectives

Get academically grounded, set a sustainable founder rhythm, and introduce yourself to the campus startup ecosystem *as someone who already ships*. Do not build new features this week — spend it on people and orientation.

Action Checklist

- ☐ Attend orientation, sort out your timetable, and block fixed “founder hours” (e.g. 2 focused evening blocks + one weekend morning) so the product never eats your coursework.
- ☐ Locate **V-NEST** (VIT Chennai’s Innovation & Entrepreneurship / incubation centre) in person. Ask how a first-year gets involved and what their intake process looks like.
- ☐ Join the **Entrepreneurship Cell (E-Cell VIT Chennai)** — follow them, get on their events list, show up to the first meetup.
- ☐ Read VIT’s **Innovation & Start-up Policy** and note the **IIC (Institution’s Innovation Council)** — know what support, credits, and protections student founders get.
- ☐ Identify 2–3 **AI/ML faculty** whose work overlaps with your product and send a short, specific intro (see script below). Aim to secure one informal mentor.
- ☐ Do “user recon”: note where seniors in placement season gather (labs, coding clubs, hostels, WhatsApp/Discord groups) — these are your first customers.

Your 30-Second Intro (use it everywhere)

“I’m Neha, first-year CSE (AI/ML). I’ve already built and deployed **ResumeForge** — it turns a student’s GitHub into a proof-backed resume and preps them for interviews. It’s live with early users. I’m looking for feedback, a mentor, and people who want to build.”

End-of-Week-1 Deliverables

A named contact at V-NEST, membership in E-Cell, one faculty mentor conversation started, and a shortlist of 15–20 senior students to approach as users.

5. Phase 1 — Weeks 2 to 4: First Users & Feedback Loop

Objectives

Get ResumeForge into the hands of 20–30 real student users and run enough deep feedback sessions to know exactly what to sharpen. This is the single most important month — it produces the traction data that unlocks everything later.

Where to Find Your First 20–30 Users

Segment	Why they convert	How to reach them
3rd/4th-year students in placement season	Urgent, painful need <i>right now</i>	Coding clubs, placement prep groups, seniors you meet via E-Cell
Peers polishing internship applications	Building first resumes with little experience	Your own class, hostel floor, study groups
Hackathon / open-source-active students	Have GitHub projects = perfect fit for the proof engine	Solve-A-Thon, dev clubs, GitHub-active seniors

How to Run a Feedback Session (15 minutes each)

Sit next to the user, ask them to complete a real task (generate a proof-backed resume for an actual role they want), and **stay silent while they use it**. Note where they hesitate, what they ignore, and what makes them say “oh, nice.” Ask two questions at the end: “*Would you pay for this?*” and “*What almost made you quit?*” Do at least 5 of these.

Co-Founder Scouting

A solo founder is a real fundraising headwind, and a campus full of CS/AI students is the best co-founder pool you’ll ever get. Start “dating” through small projects and hackathons — look for someone who complements you (if you’re strong on the build, find a growth/GTM partner). Don’t rush a commitment; test working together first.

Deliverables

20–30 users who have generated at least one resume, 5+ recorded feedback sessions, a prioritised list of the top 3 product fixes, and 1–2 potential co-founder candidates in your pipeline.

6. Phase 2 — Days 30 to 90: Traction & Proof

The 90-Day Goal

10 paying student users and clear week-2+ retention on the proof/interview flow. Hit this and you walk into V-NEST and grant committees with *evidence*, not a pitch.

Turn On Monetization

Ship the “Upgrade to Pro” paywall (your codebase already anticipates this). Gate the highest-willingness-to-pay features — interview defense, quality gate, unlimited tailored resumes — and charge

a small monthly price. A job-seeker under pressure pays for “*will this pass?*” far more than for convenience. Even a fake-door test is fine to start; the point is to learn who pays.

Hackathons & Visibility

Enter **Solve-A-Thon** and other VIT hackathons — they’re distribution, credibility, prize money, and co-founder discovery in one event. Present ResumeForge wherever you can; being “the student with a real product” becomes your reputation on campus.

Prepare for Grants & Incubation

Assemble a simple traction sheet (users, retention, revenue, testimonials) and a 5-slide story. This becomes the backbone of both your V-NEST application and your grant applications in Phase 3.

Deliverables

Working payments, first paying users, a retention number you can quote, hackathon participation, and a one-page traction sheet.

7. Phase 3 — Semester 1 to 2: Incubation, Grants & Structure

Apply to V-NEST

Once you have a working demo and early traction, formally apply to V-NEST for workspace, mentorship, and investor introductions. A faculty mentor’s backing materially improves your odds.

Decide the Legal Structure — Later, Not Now

The smart sequence for an India-based student targeting a global market: **take non-dilutive Indian grants and on-campus incubation now**, keep the entity question open, and only set up a US Delaware C-corp (the “flip”) later — when you’re actually raising from US/global investors and have retention to justify it. Do not spend money on incorporation while you still have single-digit paying users. (*This is general information, not legal or tax advice — confirm specifics with a startup lawyer/CA and with V-NEST.*)

Build the Team

Convert your strongest co-founder candidate, and line up 1–2 advisors — ideally an ex-recruiter or career-services person (domain credibility) and someone who has scaled a consumer/prosumer product.

8. The Money Map — Non-Dilutive Funding Ladder

Work *up* this ladder as you mature. Amounts and eligibility change frequently — treat these as a map, and confirm current terms with V-NEST / VIT-TBI.

Programme	What it is	Best for you	Notes
V-NEST incubation (VIT Chennai)	On-campus workspace, mentorship, investor connects	Your home base from Day 1	Apply once you have a demo + early users
DST NIDHI-PRAYAS (via VIT-TBI)	Grant for prototype / proof-of-concept by young innovators	Hardening the product	Historically up to ~Rs. 10 lakh; confirm current terms

Programme	What it is	Best for you	Notes
NIDHI-EiR (Entrepreneur-in-Residence)	Fellowship / monthly stipend to pursue the startup	Runway to work seriously	Fixed-term stipend
NIDHI Seed Support (SSS)	Seed funding for <i>incubated</i> startups	Post-incubation growth capital	Requires being incubated
MeitY TIDE 2.0 (via VIT-TBI)	Support for tech / ICT startups (EIR, PoC, scale-up grants)	Strong fit — you're a software/AI product	Confirm current call windows
BIRAC BioNEST	Biotech-focused incubation/grants	<i>Not a fit</i> for a SaaS product	Listed for completeness

9. The People Map

Who	Why you need them	Where to find them	When
First users	Feedback + proof of demand	Seniors in placement season	Week 1 onward
Co-founder	Fills your gaps; de-risks fundraising	E-Cell, hackathons, dev clubs	Weeks 2–12
Faculty mentor	Product help + grant/incubation credibility	AI/ML faculty	Week 1
V-NEST / VIT-TBI mentors	Funding, network, structure	On-campus incubators	Phase 3
Advisors	Domain + scaling credibility	Alumni, ex-recruiters	After traction

10. Your Weekly Rhythm (Sample)

A sustainable split so the product never threatens your degree. Adjust to your real timetable.

Block	Focus	Rough weekly load
Classes, labs, assignments	Protect your CGPA + AI/ML foundation	As scheduled (priority)
Deep product work	Build the top 3 fixes, ship the paywall	~8–10 hrs (2–3 evening blocks)
User calls & feedback	15-min sessions with real students	~3–4 hrs
Ecosystem	E-Cell, V-NEST, hackathons, mentor check-ins	~2–3 hrs
Rest, exercise, sleep	Non-negotiable — burnout kills startups	Daily

11. Metrics That Matter

Instrument these from day one (your **events** table already supports it). Vanity metrics like total signups don't matter — retention and payment do.

Metric	Why it matters	First target
Activation rate	% of signups who generate a real resume	> 50%
Week-2 retention	The single best signal of real value	Any clear, repeatable number
Free -> paid conversion	Proof someone will pay	First 10 paying users
Feedback sessions run	Your learning rate	5+ in month 1

12. What NOT to Do Yet

- Don't incorporate anything (especially not a foreign entity) before you have paying users and retention.
- Don't hire or take on unpaid "team members" for titles — find one real co-founder instead.
- Don't try to raise money in your first months; grants + incubation are the right fuel now.
- Don't over-market auto-apply — lead with the proof-backed resume + interview prep, your defensible wedge.
- Don't neglect academics or health for a sprint — a failing founder is not more fundable.

13. Campus & Ecosystem Resource Directory

Resource	What it offers	Link
V-NEST (VIT Chennai I&E)	On-campus incubation, mentorship, investor connects	https://chennai.vit.ac.in/innovation-and-entrepreneurship/
E-Cell VIT Chennai	Student entrepreneurship community & events	https://www.instagram.com/ecell_vitcc/
VIT-TBI	Government grant schemes & deeper incubation	https://vittbi.com/
VIT-TBI services	Funding, mentoring, infrastructure detail	https://vittbi.com/services/
Solve-A-Thon	VIT Chennai hackathon	https://solveathon.in/

14. Risks & Guardrails

The resume-tool category is crowded and low-moat, so your defensibility must come from the **proof engine** and the accumulating value of each user's evidence vault — lean into that as your retention moat. Auto-apply carries platform/ToS risk, so keep the human-clicks-submit design and treat it as one feature, not the company. You're single-vendor on Gemini, so watch AI cost per user and keep a fallback in mind. And resume tools are transactional (users churn once hired) — the counter is turning the vault + interview coach into an ongoing "career OS" they keep coming back to.

15. First-Week Checklist (tear-off)

- ☐ Timetable set; fixed founder-hours blocked
- ☐ Found V-NEST + named a contact
- ☐ Joined E-Cell VIT Chennai
- ☐ Read the Innovation & Start-up Policy; noted IIC
- ☐ Messaged 2–3 AI/ML faculty; 1 mentor conversation started
- ☐ Shortlisted 15–20 senior students to approach as users
- ☐ Practised the 30-second intro until it's automatic

This plan is general guidance, not legal, financial, or tax advice. Grant names, amounts, and eligibility change — verify current details directly with V-NEST and VIT-TBI. Sources: VIT Chennai Innovation & Entrepreneurship; V-NEST; E-Cell VIT Chennai; VIT-TBI; Solve-A-Thon.